Maša Bešlin

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Employment

FALL 2025– **Postdoctoral Associate in Syntax**, *Georgetown University.*

Education

2019–2025 **Ph.D. in Linguistics**, *University of Maryland.*

THESIS: Lexical categories, (re)categorization and locality in morphosyntax

COMMITTEE: Maria Polinsky & David Embick (co-advisors), Norbert Hornstein, Alexander Williams, Michael Israel

2015–2019 **B.A. in English Language and Literature**, *University of Novi Sad.*

2016 **Erasmus+ Student Mobility Program**, *University of Deusto.*

Research Interests

BROAD syntax and its interfaces with phonology and semantics, cognitive science

NARROW (mixed) categories, locality, raising, ellipsis, case, bare-NP adverbials, structure of the nominal phrase, argument/event structure, grammatical aspect, tense, gender, Mayan, Slavic

Publications

MANUSCRIPTS

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**. Constraining allomorphy with featural adjacency.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**. Rethinking Phase locality.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša** & Ruth Kramer. Mind the gap: Reconsidering the featural representation of grammatical gender.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**, Pavel Caha, David Embick, Stefan Ivanović, Predrag Kovačević & Utku Turk. Abstract morphological representations in real-time word comprehension: Behavioral evidence from Slavic prefixed verbs.

in prep **Bešlin, Maša** & Katherine Howitt. Island effects in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian: A large-scale acceptability study and generalization in neural language models.

JOURNAL ARTICLES

accepted **Bešlin, Maša**. Apparent voice mismatches in K'iche' ellipsis: non-distinctness, argument structure, and syntactic feature composition. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory.*

2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. Active participles are (deverbal) adjectives. *Journal of Linguistics, 1–34.* DOI: 10.1017/S0022226725000155

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Revisiting passive participles: Category status and internal structure. *Linguistic Inquiry 54*(4), 729-758. DOI: 10.1162/ling_a_00463

Book chapters

in prep **Bešlin, Maša**. Building structure and testing constituency. In *The Cambridge Companion to Generative Syntax.* Cambridge University Press.

Proceedings

in press **Bešlin, Maša**. Restricting allomorphy without spell-out opacity. In *Proceedings of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 56).*

in press **Bešlin, Maša**. Missing verbal structure in BCS agent nominals. In *Proceedings of the Formal Descriptions of Slavic Languages (FDSL 17).*

2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. On locality conditions for allomorphy and the ordering of interface operations. In *Proceedings of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 55), 67–80. University of Massachusetts Amherst: GLSA.*

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. On the incompatibility of two types of phases. In *Proceedings of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 54), 79–88.* University of Massachusetts Amherst: GLSA.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. DP in a model NP language: Evidence from Serbo-Croatian personal pronouns. In *Proceedings of the Israeli Association for Theoretical Linguistics (IATL 36)*, MIT Working Papers in Linguistics 95.

2024 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin**. Word order in Old English embedded clauses: Syntactic instantiation and pragmatic factors. In *Proceedings of ELALT 6*, Annual Review of the Faculty of Philosophy in Novi Sad.

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Reanalyzing K'iche' as a tensed language. In J. A. G. Douglas-Tavani & G. Belmar Viernes (eds.), *Proceedings of the Workshop on American Indigenous Languages (WAIL 25)*, UC Santa Barbara Linguistics Department.

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Passive *v*P is not phasal in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian. In *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America (PLSA)* 8(1). 5499.

2022 **Bešlin, Maša**. Raising as a free syntactic operation: Evidence from Serbian. In P. Kovačević, T. Milićev, & N. Milićević (eds.), *Proceedings of SinFonIJA 14, Annual Review of the Faculty of Philosophy in Novi Sad.* 63–86. University of Novi Sad: Faculty of Philosophy.

2019 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin**. Instrumental: Why it is absent from the clitic system in Serbian/Croatian. In V. Lopičić & B. Mišić-Ilić (eds.), *Proceedings of Jezik, književnost, teorija.* 153–168. University of Niš: Faculty of Philosophy.

Edited volumes

in press **Bešlin, Maša**, Katherine Howitt, Alexandra Krauska, Luisa Seguin, and Juan Uriagereka. *Structured sentences and the computational theory of mind.* Cambridge University Press.

Other publications

2025 **Bešlin, Maša** & Sadira Lewis. Exceptives in Thai. In *Variation in Exceptive Structures.* Zenodo. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.16884105

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Exceptives in K'iche'. In *Variation in Exceptive Structures.* Zenodo. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.8059592

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Exceptives in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian. In *Variation in Exceptive Structures.* Zenodo. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.7851016.

Presentations

Invited talks

2026 **Bešlin, Maša**. Beyond form and meaning: Investigating abstract morphology in language processing. Presented at:
- *Université du Québec à Montréal*
- *Masaryk University, Brno*

2026 Ruth Kramer & **Maša Bešlin**. The impoverished bishop: Gender, number, and markedness in BCS. Presented at:
- *North East Linguistics Society 57* (NELS 57), CUNY, RK keynote
- *Boston Morphology Worshop*, Boston University.

2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. Mismatches under ellipsis: Syntactic identity and theories of features. *Synsalon*, University of Arizona.

2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. Understanding the role of locality in grammar.
- *Friday Speaker Series*, Georgetown University
- *Oberseminar English Linguistics*, Georg-August-Universität, Göttingen

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. What's up with 'verbal' morphology in BCS agent nominals? *Formal Descriptions of Slavic Languages (FDSL 17)*, Masaryk University, Brno.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. Is a unified locality theory nothing but a pipe dream? (And why that may not be such a bad thing). *Yale Syntax Reading Group*, Yale University.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. Understanding the role of lexical categories in syntax and semantics. *Institute of Linguistics*, Universität Leipzig.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. What's in Universal Grammar? On participles and the inventory of grammatical primitives. Presented at:
- *Princeton Linguistics Colloquium Series,* Princeton University
- *UW-Madison Language Sciences Colloquium*, UW-Madison
- *University of Florida Linguistics Colloquium*, University of Florida

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Domain mismatches in syntax and morphophonology: Consequences for Phase theory. *SynNYU workshop*, NYU.

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. The Darwin-Plato tension, grammatical primitives, and linguistic principles. *Theoretical and Experimental Syntax Colloquium Series*, Hungarian Research Centre for Linguistics.

2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. A Mayan temporal puzzle. *Berkeley Syntax and Semantics Circle*, University of California, Berkeley.

Guest lectures

2026 **Bešlin, Maša**. Stress and tone in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian: from phonology to morphology and beyond, *Morphology/phonology Interface graduate seminar*, Georgetown University.

2020 **Bešlin, Maša**. Theory and methodology in morphological analysis: A case study of passive participles, *Theoretical Grammar undergraduate seminar*, University of Novi Sad.

Conference talks

2026 **Bešlin, Maša** & Ruth Kramer. The features of a bishop: A new approach to gender in BCS. Presented at:
- *Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics* (FASL 35), UCSC
- *West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics* (WCCFL 44), UNAM

2026 **Bešlin, Maša**, Stefan Ivanović, Predrag Kovačević & Utku Turk. The status of Slavic verbal prefixes in mental grammar: Evidence from priming in Bosnian/Croatian/Montenegrin/Serbian. *Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics* (FASL 35), UCSC.

2025 **Bešlin, Maša**. Accounting for opacity effects at the form interface without the PIC (poster). *North East Linguistics Society 56* (NELS 56), NYU.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. What *actually* delimits the context for allomorphy?. *North East Linguistics Society 55* (NELS 55), Yale University.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. Apparent voice mismatches in K'iche' ellipsis: Consequences for the Syntactic Identity Condition. *Form and Analysis in Mayan Linguistics (FAMLi VII)*, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México.

2024 **Bešlin, Maša**. Domain mismatches in syntax and morphophonology: The case of Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian adjectives (poster). *North East Linguistics Society 54* (NELS 54), Massachusetts Institute of Techonology.

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Distinct locality domains above and below the 'word' level: Evidence from Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian adjectives. *Rencontres d'Automne de Linguistique Formelle* (RALFE), Université Côte d'Azur.

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Temporal interpretation in K'iche'. *Workshop on American Indigenous Languages 25* (WAIL 25), UC Santa Barbara.

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Reanalyzing K'iche' (Mayan) as a Tensed language. *The Society for the Study of the Indigenous Languages of the Americas* (SSILA) *Annual Meeting* (online).

2023 **Bešlin, Maša**. Passive *v*P is not phasal in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian. *Linguistic Society of America 97th Annual Meeting* (LSA 97), Denver, CO.

2022 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin**. Embedded clauses in Old English: Between syntax and pragmatics. *Formal Approaches to Embedding workshop, English Language and Anglophone Literatures Today 6* (ELALT 6), University of Novi Sad.

2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. On raising-to-subject as a free syntactic operation. *Crossing boundaries: Empirical and theoretical aspects of A-dependencies in complementation workshop, 46th Austrian Linguistics Conference* (ÖLT 46), University of Vienna (online).

2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. On personal and impersonal *trebati* 'need' in Serbo-Croatian: Implications for raising. *14th Conference on Syntax, Phonology and Language Analysis* (SinFonIJA 14), University of Novi Sad (online).

2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. On the distribution of full object-pronouns in Serbo-Croatian. *16th Annual Meeting of the Slavic Linguistics Society* (SLS 16), University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (online).

2021 **Bešlin, Maša**. DP in a model NP language: Evidence from Serbo-Croatian personal pronouns. *36th Annual Conference of the Israel Association for Theoretical Linguistics* (IATL 36), Bar Ilan University (online).

2020 **Bešlin, Maša**. Encoding the eventive/resultative/stative distinction on passive participles cross-linguistically. *13th Conference on Syntax, Phonology, and Language Analysis* (SinFonIJA 13), Research Institute for Linguistics, Hungarian Academy of Sciences (online).

2020 **Bešlin, Maša**. No such thing as a *verbal participle*. *14th European Conference on Formal Description of Slavic Languages* (FDSL 14), University of Leipzig (online), moved to June 2021 due to COVID-19.

2020 **Bešlin, Maša**. What's in a name? The syntax of passive participles. *15th Annual Meeting of the Slavic Linguistics Society* (SLS 15), Indiana University Bloomington (online).

2019 **Bešlin, Maša**. On the categorial status of the passive participle in Serbo-Croatian. *Novi Sad Linguistic Colloquium 9*, University of Novi Sad.

2019 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin**. Case alternations with temporal bare-NP adverbials in Old English. *English Language and Anglophone Literatures Today 5* (ELALT 5), University of Novi Sad.

2018 **Bešlin, Maša**. How often is *subotom*? Some observations on temporal instrumentals in Serbo-Croatian. *Novi Sad Linguistic Colloquium 8*, University of Novi Sad.

2018 **Bešlin, Maša** and Predrag Kovačević. An argument in favor of a rescue-by-PF-deletion analysis of P-stranding under sluicing in Serbo-Croatian. *EGG School Open Podium*, University of Banja Luka.

2018 Milićev, Tanja and **Maša Bešlin**. Instrumental: A curious gap in the clitic system. *Jezik, književnost, teorija*, University of Niš.

2017 **Bešlin, Maša**. The case of temporal bare-NP adverbials in Serbo-Croatian. *Novi Sad Linguistic Colloquium 7*, University of Novi Sad.

Grants & Scholarships

submitted Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowship
TITLE: Abstract morphological structure in real-time word comprehension
SUPERVISORS: Pavel Caha & Jakub Dotlačil

2022–2024 College of Arts and Humanities Summer Fellowship, UMD

2023 Southeast European Studies Association Travel Grant

2022 College of Arts and Humanities Graduate Student Travel Award, UMD

2020–2024 Dean's Fellowship, UMD

2019–2020 University Fellowship, UMD

2018–2019 Serbian Government Scholarship for Gifted Students

2017–2018 Serbian Government Scholarship for Undergraduate Students

2016 Erasmus+ Scholarship

2014–2015 Woodhouse Grove School Academic Scholarship

2013–2014 The Headmasters' and Headmistresses' Conference (HMC) Projects in Central and Eastern Europe Scholarship

Awards and Honors

2023 Howard Lasnik Award for Distinguished Teaching by a Graduate Student

2022 Charles E. Townsend Memorial Award for outstanding scientific contribution to the Slavic Linguistics Society

Teaching & Advising

Ph.D. Theses (committee member)

in progress Abdullah Alasmari, *Adjectives in Hijazi Arabic: A morphosyntactic analysis.* Georgetown University. Committee: Ahmad Alqassas, **Maša Bešlin**, Matthew Hewett, Ruth Kramer

Instructor of Record

(upcoming) **LING 6128 *Syntax II***, Georgetown University
spring 2027 Graduate class, cca. 10 students

spring & fall 2026 **LING 5127 *Generative Syntax I***, Georgetown University
Graduate introductory class, 15-20 students

fall 2025 **LING 8133 *Locality: From syntax to the interfaces***, Georgetown U.
Graduate seminar, 5 students

July 2025 ***Introduction to Generative Syntax***, NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive and Linguistic Studies
Introductory class, 60 students

fall 2022 **LING 420 *Word Formation***, University of Maryland
Undergraduate seminar, 15 students

January & July 2022 ***Introduction to Generative Syntax***, NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive and Linguistic Studies, with Dr. Paulina Lyskawa
Introductory class, 60-80 students

Assistantship

fall 2024 **LING 240 *Language and Mind***, University of Maryland

July 2022 ***Verb-initial languages*** *(emphasis on Austronesian and Mayan)*,
The 4th Crete Summer School of Linguistics (CreteLing)

spring 2022 **LING 312 *Syntax II***, University of Maryland

fall 2021 **LING 311 *Syntax I***, University of Maryland

July 2021 ***Introduction to Generative Syntax***, NY-St. Petersburg Institute of Linguistics, Cognition and Culture

spring 2021 **LING 200 *Introductory Linguistics***, University of Maryland

Research Assistantship

fall 2024–spring 2025 Variation in Exceptive Structures NSF-funded project
PIs: Dr. Maria Polinsky & Dr. Eric Potsdam
Duties: mentoring students in conducting fieldwork and writing up their findings on Thai, Korean, and Hindi exceptive constructions

SPRING 2023	Variation in Exceptive Structures NSF-funded project PIs: Dr. Maria Polinsky & Dr. Eric Potsdam DUTIES: investigating the lexical, morphological, and syntactic properties of exceptives in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian (native) and K'iche' (fieldwork)

Schools and Workshops

2023 & 2024	*NYI Global Institute of Cultural, Cognitive, and Linguistic Studies*
2023	*Eastern Generative Grammar* Summer School, University of Novi Sad
2022	*The 4th Crete Summer School of Linguistics*, University of Crete
2021	*Eastern Generative Grammar* Summer School, online
2021	*NY-St. Petersburg Institute of Linguistics, Cognition and Culture*, online
2021	*Ri K'iche' Tijob'al Keb' Tz'i'*, online intensive 2-week course in K'iche', co-organized by UMD, University of Toronto and Wuqu' Kawoq
2020	*Kab'lajuj Ey 2020*, intensive 2-week course in Kaqchikel at the UMD Language Science Center's Guatemala Field Station in Patzún, Guatemala
2019	*Introduction to Statistics: R*, University of Novi Sad
2018	*Eastern Generative Grammar* Summer School, University of Banja Luka
2018	*6th Novi Sad Workshop on Psycholinguistic, Neurolinguistic and Clinical Linguistic Research*, University of Novi Sad
2017	*Eastern Generative Grammar* Summer School, Palacký University Olomouc
2017	*Introduction to Neurolinguistics*, University of Novi Sad

Service

Reviewing

JOURNALS	Linguistic Inquiry, Natural Language & Linguistic Theory, Glossa: A journal of general linguistics, Journal of Slavic Linguistics, Catalan Journal of Linguistics, Folia Linguistica, Linguistica Brunensia, Annual Review of the Faculty of Philosophy, University of Novi Sad
BOOK	Advances in Formal Slavic Linguistics 2023, 2025, Language Science Press
CHAPTERS	Cambridge Handbook of Comparative Syntax, Cambridge University Press
	Semantics of Slavic Languages, Language Science Press
CONFERENCES	Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics (FASL 34 & 35)
	Formal Descriptions of Slavic Languages (FDSL 17)
	Syntax, Phonology, and Language Analysis (SinFonIJA 14, 16, 17 & 19)
	The Society for the Study of the Indigenous Languages of the Americas Annual Meeting (SSILA 2025 & 2026)
	West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 44)

Other service

2025–	Member of the Department Framework Committee, Georgetown University
2022–	Proofreader for Language Science Press
2024	Co-organizer for *Mayfest 2024* in honor of Masha Polinsky, UMD
2023	Co-organizer for *Mayfest 2023* in honor of Howard Lasnik, UMD

2022 Co-organizer for *Mayfest 2020(+2)* in honor of Norbert Hornstein, UMD

2022 Volunteer at *Maryland Day*, open house at UMD for the local community

2022 Proctor for the *North American Computational Linguistics Olympiad*

2021–2023 Student Representative for the Linguistics department, Dean's Graduate Advisory Board, UMD

2021 Co-organizer for *Syntax, Phonology and Language Analysis 14 (SinFonIJA 14)*, University of Novi Sad (online)

2020–2021 Co-organizer, General Linguistics Lab Meeting, UMD

2018 Co-author and coordinator of the *Universal Grammar and Language Ability* workshop at the International Festival of Science and Education, University of Novi Sad

Other Work Experience

2015–2023 Freelance translator English>Serbian, Spanish>Serbian, Serbian>English

2018 Interpreter (Spanish>Serbian, Serbian>Spanish) at *Koteks Viscofan* in Novi Sad, Serbia

2016–2019 Tutor for the courses English grammar 3, English Grammar 4, Generative Syntax 1 and Generative Syntax 2 at the University of Novi Sad

2015–2018 Freelance language teacher for English and Spanish

Professional Membership

2022– Society for the Study of Indigenous Languages of the Americas (SSILA)

2020– Linguistic Society of America (LSA)

2020– Slavic Linguistics Society (SLS)

Technical Skills

MS Office, PCIbex Farm, Praat, PsychoPy, SPSS, LaTeX

Languages

native Serbian (Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian)

fluent English, Spanish

beginner German

fieldwork K'iche', Kaqchikel

References (in order)

Professor Maria Polinsky
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Associate Professor Ruth Kramer
Georgetown University
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Professor Heather Newell
Université du Québec à Montréal
Pavillon J.A. De Sève, local DS-4427
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